

Afternoon Discoveries

Thursday September 24, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Romance, Women's Fiction & Historical Fiction

History has a habit of intruding on private lives.

A relationship can feel like something belonging entirely to two people until family, war, work, reputation, money, or the expectations of an era enter the room. Today's discoveries move from occupied Norway and post-war Greece to a university campus, Hollywood, storm-chasing highways, and the English countryside. Across very different books, the question underneath them is surprisingly similar: what happens when the life you want collides with the world around you?

Several of today's books are arriving this week, including two publishing in the UK and Commonwealth today.

All links were checked against the linked publisher, author, literary organization, interview, or archival page on September 24, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Sisters of the Midnight Sun - Fiona Valpy

In Shetland in 2001, Ruby Reid begins caring for Hanna, an elderly woman who has withdrawn from the world. Hanna's story reaches back to Norway in 1940, where the German occupation overturns her life and forces her to make increasingly difficult choices while trying to protect her twin sister, Liv.

What makes the premise particularly interesting is the distance between those two timelines. Ruby does not simply uncover a piece of wartime history. She encounters what remains of it

inside another person decades later. Loss, memory, sisterhood, and the possibility of beginning again connect the two women across generations.

The novel was released in the United States on September 15 and publishes today in the UK and Commonwealth. Valpy has also written about the book's roots in the wartime relationship between Norway and Shetland, making this one of today's discoveries with considerably more to explore beyond the novel itself.

Penguin

[Visit the publisher page for Sisters of the Midnight Sun](#)

The Discovery Desk

The Winter Bride **- Rosie Goodwin**

Nuneaton, 1922. Annie has survived a childhood in the workhouse and the battlefields of the First World War, built a successful business, and found security with her adopted family and fiancé, Monty. What she has not managed to leave behind is Alex Gordon, the man she once loved.

When old secrets unsettle the life she has constructed, Annie starts again in London with plans for a dress shop. Alex's return complicates the question of whether the safer future is necessarily the one she wants.

Published today, *The Winter Bride* is the third novel in Goodwin's *Rags to Riches* trilogy. Its romance grows out of a larger story about class, work, family, and the difficult business of deciding

what should be carried forward from the past.

[Bonnier Books](#)

[Visit the publisher page for The Winter Bride](#)

The Wine-Dark Sea **- Victoria Hislop**

Greece, 1946. Civil war has followed almost immediately after the Second World War, and Fotini is separated from her children when government soldiers arrive at her village. Imprisoned on the island of Chios, she befriends Markella and her young son, Nikos. When the women are separated again, Fotini makes a promise that extends beyond her own family.

Hislop places an intimate story of motherhood inside a period when entire families could be moved, divided, or lost through forces far beyond their control. The result is historical fiction concerned not only with what war destroys, but with the obligations people form while trying to survive it.

The Australian trade paperback appeared September 22, with the ebook and audiobook editions releasing today.

[Hachette Australia](#)

[Explore The Wine-Dark Sea at Hachette](#)

Hollywood, Ending **- John Green**

Kai Laramie and Juniper Castillo are rising actors who land roles in *Andy Warhol Never Gets Old*, a film that could transform

both of their careers. It might also turn an emerging attraction into something the rest of the world believes it has a right to watch.

Green's first new novel in years, published September 22, approaches romance through the strange machinery of contemporary fame. Kai and Juniper are trying to determine whether they can trust each other at precisely the moment when their private selves are becoming increasingly valuable public material.

The publisher describes it as a Hollywood love story, but its more unusual concern is what happens when affection, ambition, performance, and attention become almost impossible to separate.

[PenguinRandomhouse.com](https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com)

[Visit the publisher page for Hollywood, Ending](#)

Love Between the Lectures **- *Christie Curry***

June Wells grew up inside purity culture and has built an adult life almost deliberately opposed to it. She is now a human sexuality professor nearing tenure when Alex Cardoso, her childhood neighbour and former crush, reappears.

The two are paired to organize a sexual-health event at June's university. Then some of the institution's largest donors, led by June's conservative parents, object.

Published September 22, the novel gives its romantic conflict something more substantial to push against than simple miscommunication. June's professional independence, family history, and relationship with Alex all begin pressing on the

same unresolved parts of her life.

PenguinRandomhouse.com

Visit the publisher page for *Love Between the Lectures*

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Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

More From the Discovery Desk

Doom Painting **- A. K. Blakemore**

England in 1381 is still living in the shadow of plague and foreign war when an encounter between two childhood friends and a local Justice helps ignite a much larger rebellion.

Blakemore's novel follows the Peasants' Revolt across sixteen days as ordinary people march toward London and Wat Tyler emerges as one of its leaders. Rather than using the uprising merely as background for a smaller fictional drama, *Doom Painting* places the rebellion itself at the centre and moves among the people caught inside it.

Granta publishes the 672-page novel today. It is one of the most directly historical selections in this edition, and a useful reminder that historical fiction can make collective upheaval, rather than a single famous life, its protagonist.

Granta

[Explore Doom Painting at Granta](#)

Chase Me If You Can **- Heather Frances**

Most of the year, Sloane Michaels photographs weddings. For six weeks each spring, she chases tornadoes.

When a nature magazine announces a storm-cover competition, Sloane sees an opening into the landscape-photography career she wants. The main obstacle is Wes Talbot, a reckless storm chaser, long-time frenemy, and the person she most needs to beat. After Wes is injured, however, the two end up chasing the season together.

Chase Me If You Can gives its romance unusually kinetic surroundings. The central pair are not simply forced into proximity. They are travelling toward the same dangerous weather while competing for the same professional opportunity.

Penguin

[Visit the publisher page for Chase Me If You Can](#)

The Silent Women **- Tara Lynn Masih**

Tara Lynn Masih's new historical novel reaches from the Dust Bowl through the development of the atomic bomb and into post-war Florida, following a woman named Song through clandestine love, war trauma, and the consequences that continue after the historical event itself has ended.

The author's own site lists the book as launching September 9 and describes it as a story concerned with courage, resilience, and a remarkable woman living through several major changes in twentieth-century American life.

There is something appealing about historical fiction that refuses to let history stop at the event we already recognize. *The Silent Women* appears interested in what comes before the famous moment and, perhaps more importantly, what remains afterward.

Tara Lynn Masih

[Discover The Silent Women on Tara Lynn Masih's website](#)

Isn't He Romantic? **- Adib Khorram**

Arya has built his romantic life around keeping things temporary. Approaching forty while his friends increasingly pair off has begun to make that certainty less comfortable.

Then his latest one-night stand, Ben, turns out to be the new chair of a charity event Arya's company is planning. When Ben's ex arrives hoping for a reconciliation, Ben claims he is already seeing Arya. Arya agrees to continue the fiction in exchange for Ben's help winning a client.

Published September 22, Khorram's novel takes the familiar fake-dating structure and gives both men reasons to resist

what the arrangement is beginning to reveal. The question is less whether the performance will become real than whether either of them is prepared to alter the lives they built before meeting.

Hachette Book Group

[Visit the publisher page for Isn't He Romantic?](#)

Farewell to Eden **- Sebastian Faulks**

Philip Deval returns from Normandy and is sent to Palestine during the final days of the British Mandate. Years later, teaching at a school in the English countryside, he meets music teacher Frances Darwood.

Their evenings listening to records gradually draw them closer, but the experiences Philip has carried home do not remain neatly in the past. Faulks uses the relationship to examine what peace actually asks of someone who has survived war but has not entirely escaped it.

Released September 17, *Farewell to Eden* spans Palestine and post-war Britain while keeping its attention on the quieter consequences of historical violence: memory, faith, intimacy, and the possibility of constructing an ordinary future afterward.

Penguin

[Visit the publisher page for Farewell to Eden](#)

Never Lasting **- Angela Bourassa**

Lucy has recently graduated from NYU law and intends to work abroad. James is a caterer who wants to open a restaurant in a small town. Both know they will soon be moving to opposite sides of the planet.

That makes six weeks seem like a manageable amount of time for something deliberately temporary.

Published September 22 by 831 Stories, Bourassa's debut novella starts with an unusually clear expiration date and then asks what happens when the emotional arrangement refuses to obey the practical one. At 208 pages, it is also one of today's shorter book-length discoveries.

Simon & Schuster

[Visit the publisher page for *Never Lasting*](#)

The Rally **- Carla Vass**

Charlotte "Charlie" Walker has spent four years building the successful dating app Flutter. After rejecting the advances of her cofounder, she finds herself pushed out of the company she helped create.

Her response is not particularly restrained. Charlie joins her best friend on an extravagant European car rally and enters a world of luxury vehicles, parties, wealth, and people who seem to live beyond ordinary consequences. Unfortunately, the company she left behind has secrets of its own, and an unexpected attraction makes the escape considerably less simple.

Publishing September 29, *The Rally* sits comfortably between romance and contemporary women's fiction, particularly in its

interest in professional power, friendship, reinvention, and what a woman does when ownership of her own work is suddenly challenged.

[Hachette Book Group](#)

[Explore The Rally at Hachette](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Sisters of the Midnight Sun: Interview with Fiona Valpy - *Elisabeth Storrs with Fiona Valpy*

If today's Featured Discovery catches your attention, this September 13 conversation provides a worthwhile second layer.

Valpy explains that the novel originally began with her interest in the Shetland Bus, the small vessels that travelled between Shetland and Nazi-occupied Norway carrying refugees, agents, and commandos. As her research developed, the largely overlooked roles of women in the Norwegian resistance became increasingly important to the book.

She also discusses why she returns to dual timelines. Her shorthand is three ideas: contrast, connection, and congruence. That is a compact craft framework for understanding how two periods can do more than simply alternate chapters.

[Elisabeth Storrs Historical Novels](#)

[Read the interview with Fiona Valpy](#)

Shelf Life **- John Green**

John Green's September 22 installment of *Shelf Life* begins with *Hollywood, Ending* and then moves outward toward books that shaped him as a reader.

The most useful part for today's edition comes before the recommendations. Green explains that he began the novel interested in the machinery that turns private experience into public content, particularly in a world where ordinary people increasingly place pieces of their lives on display. While writing, however, the novel also became concerned with the more intimate question of how love helps people endure difficult periods.

That progression makes an interesting companion to the novel itself: a book that began with attention and celebrity ultimately led its author toward survival and attachment.

ELLE

[Read Shelf Life: John Green at ELLE](#)

Member Spotlight: Tara Lynn Masih **- The Authors Guild**

The Authors Guild spoke with Tara Lynn Masih on September 21 about writing practice, persistence, criticism, and the relationship between authors and readers.

Masih says her difficulty is not a lack of ideas but choosing one strong enough to hold her attention through a novel. For creative blocks more generally, she recommends repetitive

physical activity such as walking, allowing the mind to work without placing it directly under pressure. She also describes learning to accept useful criticism while keeping damaging criticism outside.

With *The Silent Women* newly published, the conversation offers something the book page cannot: a sense of the working habits behind the historical fiction.

The Authors Guild

[Read the Authors Guild conversation with Tara Lynn Masih](#)

Special Recommendations

The Blue Castle **- L. M. Montgomery**

One hundred years after its original 1926 publication, *The Blue Castle* still has an unusually modern engine.

Twenty-nine-year-old Valancy Stirling has spent her life constrained by a controlling family and by other people's expectations of what her life should look like. A startling medical diagnosis finally pushes her to stop cooperating. She begins speaking honestly, moves away from her relatives, and eventually proposes marriage to the mysterious Barney Snaith.

Montgomery is best known for *Anne of Green Gables*, but this adult novel gives independence and romance equal importance. Valancy does not discover a different life because someone arrives to rescue her. The romance becomes possible after she begins choosing for herself.

Project Gutenberg provides the novel free to read and identifies it as romance fiction, a story of single women, love, choice, and self-actualization.

[Project Gutenberg](#)

[Read The Blue Castle free at Project Gutenberg](#)

The Age of Innocence **- Edith Wharton**

Love in *The Age of Innocence* is never simply a question of what one person wants from another. Marriage, class, social expectations, reputation, and belonging surround every intimate decision.

That makes Wharton's novel an especially fitting companion to today's newer books. The particulars have changed, but the pressure created when private desire meets a public role has not disappeared. Project Gutenberg's catalog fittingly places the novel among love stories, domestic fiction, marriage, interpersonal triangles, separation, and upper-class life.

Return to it less for romance as escape than for the opposite: romance as a way of revealing the structure of the world around the people experiencing it.

[Project Gutenberg](#)

[Read The Age of Innocence at Project Gutenberg](#)

*Today's selections keep returning to one tension from very different directions:
love may feel private, but lives rarely are.*

War reaches into families. Careers alter relationships. Reputation changes what can safely be said. Money creates choices for some people and removes them for others. Even a storm chase or six week fling comes attached to a future waiting outside it.

Perhaps that is one reason romance and historical fiction sit so naturally beside each other. Both can ask what a person wants. The interesting part begins when the world answers back.

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Take care!
